

Steel skull cap
This light, close-fitting skull cap was worn by a Landsknecht soldier c.1510. Secured with a chinstrap, it afforded all-round vision as well as essential protection.

not permitted to fight for the emperor's enemies, but finding imperial pay inadequate or insufficiently reliable, companies sought a different master. The French king, François I, was able to buy the services of a "Black Band" regiment of renegade Landsknechts at least similar in numbers to the imperial mercenaries.

In 1515, François I led an army across the Alps into Italy to fight the Swiss for possession of Milan. At Marengo, on 13–14 September, the confident Swiss pikemen, considered the supreme infantry force in Europe, attacked the French king's lines full tilt. But the Landsknechts absorbed the momentum of the charging phalanx and the two forces of pikemen swayed back and forth in a deadly pushing contest. An eventual French victory, after some 28 hours of intermittent butchery, depended as much upon François' cavalry and artillery as upon the foot soldiers. But the defeat of the Swiss inevitably sent the Landsknechts' stock soaring. In 1525, when the army of the new emperor, Charles V, took on the French at Pavia, the Landsknechts were at the heart of the combat on both sides. The imperial pikemen made a vital contribution to a crushing victory for Charles' forces, but the Black Band earned the greater fame by fighting to the last man after the rest of the French army had fled the field.

LATE DECLINE

The Landsknechts never performed with this level of commitment again. Fighting as "lansquenets" during the French Wars of Religion in the second half of the 16th century, they were sometimes disparaged even by those who employed them. Spain's general, the Duke of Alva, entrusted with suppressing the Dutch revolt, claimed that he bought the Landknechts' services not because they were any use in battle, but so that they could not appear fighting on the other side. Whatever their later decadence, however, the Landsknechts had left an enduring legend as the quintessential Renaissance mercenaries.

LANDSKNECHT TACTICAL FORMATIONS

The Landsknechts' battle tactics were primarily designed for symmetrical combat against the opposing army's pikemen. Unlike the Swiss, the Landsknechts do not seem to have used their pike phalanx for a shock charge into the enemy line. Instead they typically stood on the defensive or advanced at a steady grinding pace. As two dense pike-wielding phalanxes approached one another, arquebusiers or crossbowmen on the flanks of the Landsknecht phalanx would fire into the enemy ranks, hoping to weaken and disrupt their formation. At the same time the fearsome Landsknecht *doppelsöldner* would advance ahead of the mass of pikes, attacking the enemy pikemen with blows from their halberds and massive two-handed swords. If the Landsknechts retained formation, their pikemen were invulnerable to all but missile weapons, their pikes forming an unbreachable barrier. Once the formation was disrupted, however, the pike was a clumsy weapon. Most Landsknechts carried a short sword, the *katzbalger*, for close-quarters combat.

Gevierte ordnung

Adopted from the Swiss, this *gevierte ordnung* (square order) formation was typically made by a single *fähnlein* (company) of 400 men. It was often preceded by an advance party, or "forlorn hope", of criminals, prisoners, and volunteers seeking promotion. A regiment consisted of ten *fähnleins*.



KEY



Defensive igel

When attacked by cavalry, the *fähnlein* would form a defensive *igel* (hedgehog). Arquebusiers retreated to the third row, while pikemen came forward with pikes extended in all directions. (The numbers shown here are greatly reduced.)

